Put your thinking hat on!



The six thinking hats of Edward de Bono

Edward de Bono

"Thinking is the ultimate human resource. Yet we can never be satisfied with our most important skill. No matter how good we become, we should always want to be better"

Parallel Thinking

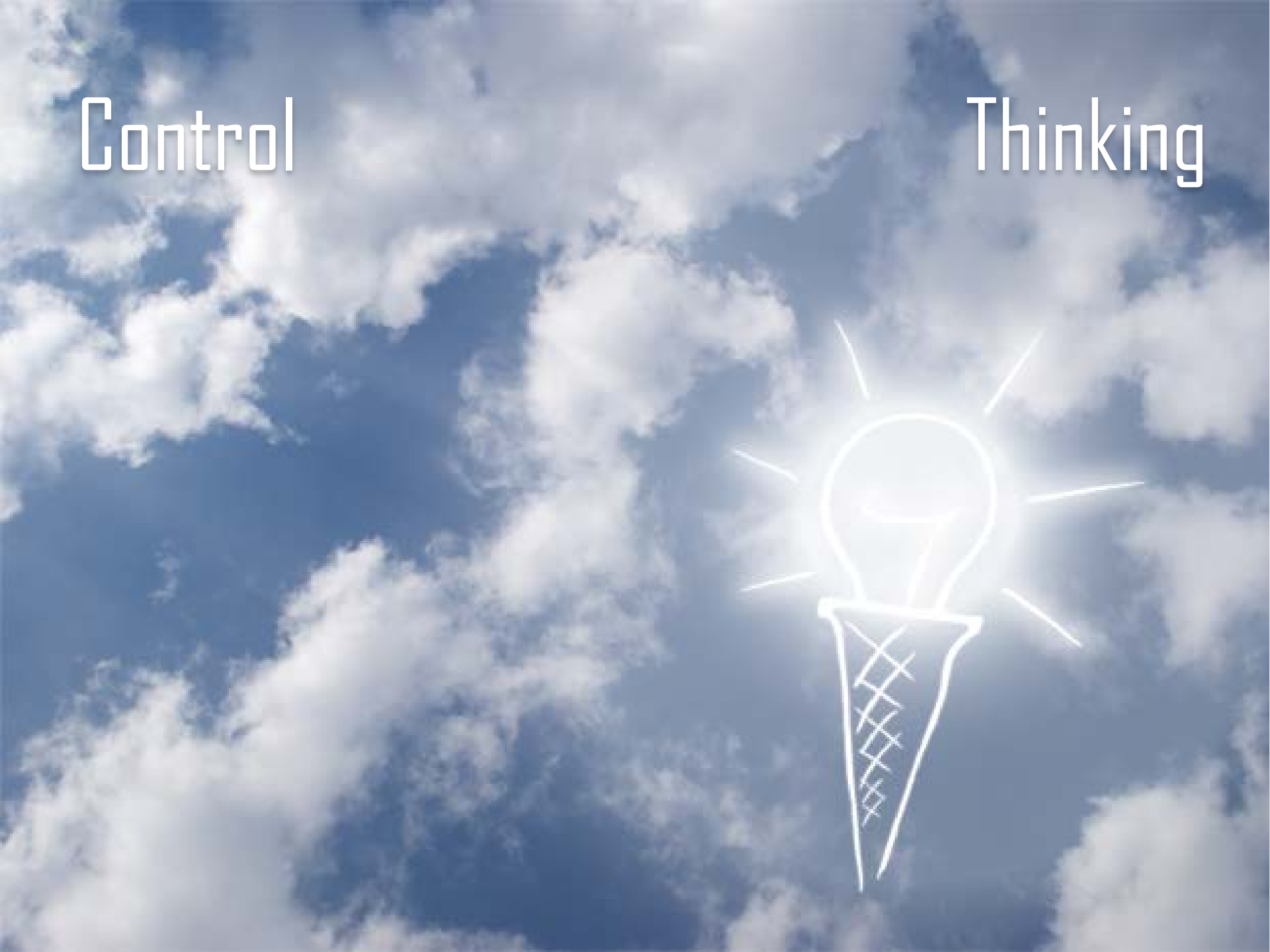
- **Parallel Thinking** is an alternative to Argument. In **Parallel Thinking** each thinker puts forward his or her thoughts in **parallel** with the thoughts of others, rather than attacking the thoughts of others.
- Guides thought processes in one direction at a time, so we can effectively analyse issues, generate new ideas and make better decisions.
- It is a constructive alternative to arguments
- Hats help a group use parallel thinking
- You can "put on" and "take off" a hat – they are directions of thinking

Six thinking hats

In his book "Six Thinking Hats" Edward de Bono presents a simple but effective way to become a better thinker. He separates thinking into six distinct modes, identified with six coloured "thinking hats"




CONTROL
DIRECTION
PROCESS
MANAGE
COORDINATE
FOCUS
ORGANIZE
SKY


Control
Thinking

Blue hat thinking

The blue hat stands for process, control, or taking an overview. Think of the blue sky over us. Wearing the blue hat means taking a wider, higher perspective to ensure you are addressing the right issue.

Blue Hat

Managing the Thinking Process



- Control of thinking & the process
- Instructions for thinking
- The organization of thinking
- Control of the other hats
- Begin & end session with blue hat
- Discipline and focus
- Facilitator, session leader's role

Questions to ask...



What is our focus?
What thinking is needed?
What have we done so far?
What do we do next?



Information



Facts

White hat thinking

The white hat is neutral, objective and non-emotional. White is effectively colourless. Focus instead on the facts and figures, on the data and information available. You try to extrapolate trends from historical data and search for gaps in the knowledge



Questions to ask?



What information do we have
What information do we need




harmony
optimism
BENEFITS
Positivity
greatness
LOGICAL
STRENGTHS
OPTIMISM
PLUSES
GREATNESS
POSITIVITY
HARMONY
logical
strengths
benefits
pluses
optimism
positivity
harmony
greatness

BENEFITS HARMONY



HAVE A GREAT DAY!

Yellow hat thinking

The yellow hat is sunny and optimistic. Take time to be hopeful! Think positively! This viewpoint will help you to see all the benefits and the value in the decision



Questions to ask?



What are the good things about this?
What are the strengths and pluses?
How will it help us?
Why will it work?
Question: What are the good points of being tall?




INNOVATION
IDEAS
GROWTH
POSSIBILITY
SOLUTIONS
CREATIVITY
ALTERNATIVES


Growth
Creativity

Green hat thinking

The green hat stands for the creation of ideas, concepts and perceptions. Imagine a tree, branching out and growing. When you are wearing the green hat, you are concerned with change, and escaping old ideas in order to find better ones. There is no criticism or judgement



Questions to ask?



What is possible?
What ideas do you have?
Can we combine these ideas?
What would happen if?


intuition
feeling
gut
INTUITION
heart
INSTINCT
HEART
emotion
FEELING
GUT
EMOTION
instinct


Emotion
Intuition

Red hat thinking

The red hat is the emotional hat, where you can present views based on intuition, instinct, without explanation or justification. Look at problems based on your gut reaction, on your feelings. Try to understand the responses of people who do not understand your reasoning



Questions to ask?



What is your gut reaction?
How do you feel about this right now?
What is your intuition telling you?
Exercise: Listen to this music - how does it make you feel?
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=zHvBPwNUBS8

judgement
problems
issues
negative
gloomy
caution
stern
flaws
risks
difficulties
DIFFICULTIES
NEGATIVE
CAUTION
GLOOMY
STERN
FLAWS
RISKS
ISSUES
PROBLEMS
JUDGEMENT


Problems
Caution

Black hat thinking

The black hat is gloomy and negative. You take time to look at the risks and why a proposed solution will fail. Black hat thinking helps to make plans tougher, more resilient. It can help you to spot fatal flaws. It can be over-used.



Questions to ask?



What problems could we face?
What are the potential risks?
What might go wrong with this
What are the weaknesses?

…and close with the blue hat



- What we have achieved
- Outcome
- Conclusion
- Design
- Solution
- Next steps



Using the hats

- Use any hat, as often as needed
- Sequence can be preset or evolving
- Not necessary to use every hat
- Time under each hat: generally, short
- Requires discipline from each person
  - While using it, stay in the idiom
- Can be used by individuals and groups

General hat issues

- **Direction, not description**
  - Set out to think in a certain direction
  - "Let's have some black hat thinking…"
- **Not categories of people**
  - Not: "He's a black hat thinker."
  - Everyone can and should use all the hats
- **A constructive form of showing off**
  - Show off by being a better thinker
  - Not destructive right vs. wrong argument
- **Use in whole or in part**

Single Hat and Sequence Use

- The hats can be used singly at any point in thinking. In general, this is the major use. The hats are used as a convenience for directing thinking and for switching thinking.
- Simple sequences of two or three hats may be used together for a particular purpose.

  For example, *the **yellow hat** followed by the **black hat** may be used to assess an idea. The **black hat** followed by the **green hat** may be used to improve a design.* *(All Weather bike)*

Evaluation Sequence of Hats

- To discover the **positive aspects and negative aspects** of an idea. You use the yellow hat before you use the **black** hat.
- You could follow up with the green hat (new ideas) and then red hat (feelings and emotions).
- To use **design sequences**, this encourages new ideas, products or improvements to existing designs. Use the blue, green and red hats
- Red then white – compares fact with opinion
- Black, then yellow then green is comparing and synthesising – coming up with new ideas from the known
- White then blue, what do we know in facts and where do we plan to go

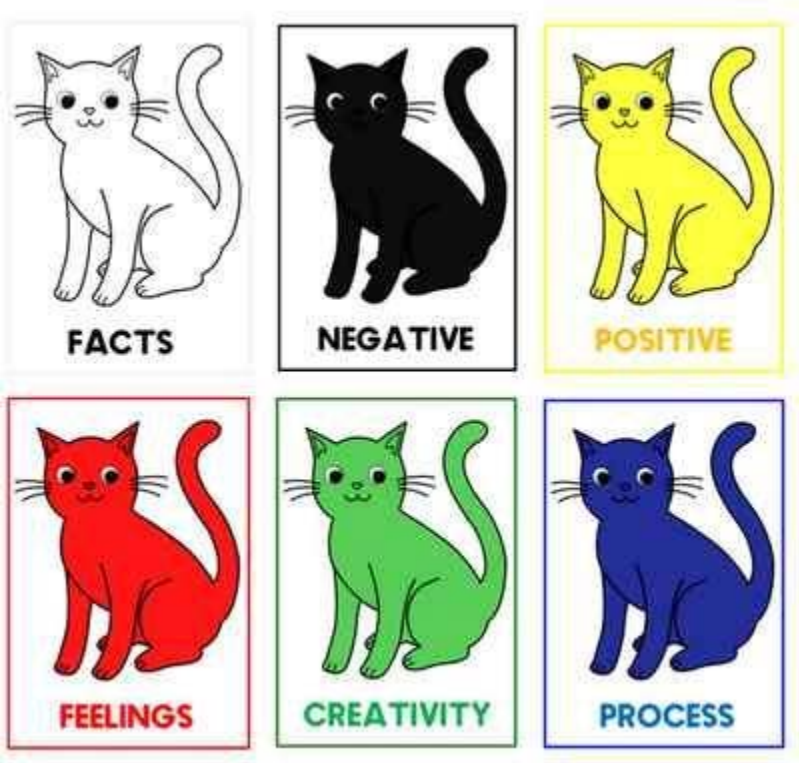
Benefits of Six Thinking Hats

- Provides a common language
- Experience & intelligence of each person (Diversity of thought)
- Helps people work against type, preference
- Removal of ego (reduce confrontation)
- Focus (one thing at a time)
- Create, evaluate & implement action plans



6 Thinking Hats explained

- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=maWEAnSegcc



Summary


DE BONOS SIX THINKING HATS
INFORMATION
Facts
Information
Documentation
Known/Unknown
No options
MANAGE
Observe
Objectives
Goal
Rules
Big picture
BRIGHTNESS
Optimism
Positives
Benefits
Make it work
Values
SIX THINKING HATS
JUDGEMENT
Negatives
Caution
Logic
Faults
Danger
EMOTIONS
Feeling
Intuition
Emotions
Don't rationalize
Don't justify
CREATIVITY
Possibility
New ideas
Alternatives
Concepts
Growth